



IN BEIJING, AN INDIAN BOXER HAD TO BE DRAGGED AWAY BEFORE HE TOOK A SWING AT AN INDIAN OFFICIAL DUMPING NON-STOP ON AKHIL KUMAR AFTER HIS DEFEAT.

where Indians have been internationally successful, are formidable and many. It is why Indian boxing needed an Olympic medal, to act as force multiplier, to become the country's mass-based individual sport which discriminated only on basis of intensity and want. Combined with wrestler Sushil Kumar's bronze that was nailed three hours before Vijender entered the ring, India had its best day at the Olympics ever and Beijing became its best-ever Olympics.

The Beijing Olympics will, one way or another, mark a watershed year for Indian boxing. The sport's profile is as high as it has ever been, yet India's public memory is non-existent. What every boxer in Beijing fears is not physical pain but the brutality of anonymity. After Sydney, Gurcharan found that there were no safety nets for him and left India to pursue a professional career in the US. India cannot afford to lose its finest generation of fighters to a philosophy of mediocrity. It cannot throw away the futures of men and of an entire sport for the lack of modern coaching and medical back-up.

It took a late dash across red tape to get Matthews, hired by the Mittal Champion's Trust, to the team in time. The boxers call Matthews their, "physio, doctor, mother, father, teacher" because his is a bewildering range of duties: joint-fixer, nutrition-instructor, food-monitor, Internet-guru and the fellow who introduced them to olives. The night Jitender's chin was cut open in Beijing, Matthews located a plastic surgeon to stitch it within hours. The fighters have thrived from his expertise and he from their faith.

AFP PHOTO



GRACIOUS EXIT: Akhil Kumar had reached the quarter-final by defeating world champion Sergey Vodopyanov

Indian boxing has found its right time: it now needs the right people to man the right places. It is reckoned that more than 15,000 compete at all levels of boxing in India. Starting with 2003, its junior boxers have cleaned up golds in every age-group world championships. There is both depth and competitiveness and the results from India's five-man army in Beijing has taken the sport to the lip of a tipping point. Crossing over into take-off territory is up to those who run the sport. "There will soon be a great exodus towards boxing and we have to be ready for it," says Jay Kowli, secretary of the International Amateur Boxing

Association (AIBA) youth panel and joint secretary of the Indian Amateur Boxing Federation (IABF). He recommends decentralising administration at zonal levels, ("we can't work only through three people in an office in Delhi") and actively reaching out to prospective sponsors. Strengthening the sport at school level will deepen the talent pool which in turn, it is hoped, will improve the quality of the national championships. The first ever national inter-school championship (for under-17s) was held only last November in Akola. Kowli is pushing for an under-14 event too.

"This result shows that our system is in place and it is working—not like K.P.S. Gill and hockey. But now we will have the challenge of meeting the expectations of people." For his part, Kowli is going to use Indian boxing's Olympic high noon as the pre-

text to financially reward boxers and coaches in Maharashtra, where he is the general secretary.

Boxing, it seems, is elemental at every level: its upgradation in India does not require Olympian budgets. By Kowli's estimates, a small state association would need between Rs 5 lakh and Rs 10 lakh to run all its operations while a larger state association like Maharashtra would need between Rs 15 lakh and Rs 25 lakh. He says, "If I could get Rs 25 lakh per annum, we can assure you success after five years." Does success mean financial profit or medals? "Both," Kowli says. He understood that his sport was onto something monumental when not long ago, he received an email from an Indian boxer, a young Asian championship winner. The email said, "The Olympic gold is my dream." ■